PAROXETINE

Worst withdrawal of SSRIs

Avoid in pregnancy

CHEMICAL NAME (3S,4R)-3-[(1,3-benzodioxol-5-yloxy)methyl]-4-(4-fluorophenyl)piperidine (hydrochloride)

CLASS Selective serotonin reuptake inhibitor (SSRI)

TRADE NAMES Seroxat · Paxil · Aropax · Paxetin

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Major depression.
- Panic disorder, social anxiety, GAD, PTSD.
- OCD.
- Menopausal hot flushes (low dose, some countries).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily in the morning with food; do not crush CR tablets.

DOSAGES

- **Depression/social anxiety:** 20 mg once daily; max 50 mg.
- **Panic:** start 10 mg, target 40 mg.
- **OCD:** 40 mg (max 60 mg).
- Elderly/renal/hepatic: max 40 mg.
- Taper by 10 mg/week (or slower).

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 2–4 weeks.
- Metabolised by CYP2D6 (non-linear; potent inhibitor).
- **t½:** ~21 h; no active metabolites → marked discontinuation syndrome.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Monitor mood, suicidality.
- Plan slow taper.
- Check pregnancy plans.
- Check tamoxifen use.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Potent **5-HT reuptake** inhibitor with anticholinergic activity.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea, drowsiness, dry mouth, constipation.
- Sexual dysfunction (high), sweating.
- Weight gain.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Discontinuation syndrome: dizziness, electric-shock sensations, irritability, flu-like symptoms.
- Suicidality (young people).
- Congenital cardiac malformations (1st trimester).
- Serotonin syndrome; hyponatraemia; bleeding.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- MAOIs; thioridazine, pimozide.
- Pregnancy (relative — avoid).
- Children (depression; not recommended).

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Tamoxifen:** ↓ activation (CYP2D6) — avoid.
- **MAOIs, tramadol, triptans:** serotonin syndrome.
- **TCAs, metoprolol:** ↑ levels.
- **Anticoagulants, NSAIDs:** bleeding.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take in the morning with food.
- Never stop suddenly; follow taper.
- Avoid in pregnancy; discuss plans.
- Report worsening mood.

KEY POINTS

- SSRI with anticholinergic effects.
- Avoid in pregnancy and with tamoxifen.
- Worst discontinuation syndrome.
- 20 mg daily.

SOURCES CHECKED **[771]** Paroxetine 10 mg Tablets (UK SmPC) **[772]** Paroxetine, oral (US label) **[773]** Paroxetine, oral (US label, NuCare Pharmaceuticals)

Full references p. 432–457